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Photos and Text
By Steve Jennings

THE WEEKND



Back in March, The Weeknd was another band on tour, doing festivals and one-offs. Then the band exploded, the Grammy nominations came in, and they're now touring with a full Clair Global rig, including, according to systems engineer Paul Jump, "the Clair Cohesion 12 System for the main hang. We have 16 cabinets per side covering the arenas. Along with the Cohesion 12 are six Clair CP218 subs hanging behind the Cohesion 12, as well as six CP218 per side on the ground. Covering the sides of the arena is the Clair I3 System. We are using six Cohesion 8 speakers for front fills. The Cohesion 12, the i3, and Cohesion 8 are powered by Lab.gruppen PLM 20k amplifiers and the CP218 are self-powered."



The Weeknd audio crew, from left: Michael Robertson, monitor tech; Paul Jump, systems engineer; Derek Brener, FOH Engineer; Andy Ebert, monitor engineer; Jon Barrows, P.A. tech; Ken Fiedler, P.A. tech.

"I opted to use an Avid Profile for the one-offs in the beginning of the year, as I knew that this desk would be the most widely available around the country and in-house at most festivals," says **FOH engineer Derek Brener**. "The mix became so dialed that, for tour, I just upgraded to a D-Show for more tangible control."

"The input list is 66 channels for drums, bass, guitar, keys, tracks, vocals and talk-backs. I primarily and sparingly use plug-ins from Waves, [Avid] VENUEPack 4, and a few that are factory-installed. I use SSL and CLA plugs for the band, the C6 for Abel, and the L2 for the L/R bus. For vocal effects, I use the Waves Doubler and Harmonizer, GTR for distortion, Moogerfooger analog delay for slap, H-Delay for dirty stereo delay, [Avid] Extra Long Delay for clean stereo delays, and [Avid] D-Verb for short and long verbs. I never get too crazy with plug-ins. I would sooner not put a plug-in on something if it already has the sound that I'm after."

"I carry two outboard units from one of my favorite companies: a Distressor for Abel's compressor, and a Fatso Jr. for drum compression. I love the character that EL [Empirical Labs] units bring to the mix...always have. The Distressor gives Abel transparent compression, brings a round warmth to his falsetto, and a salty saturation when he hits it hard. These units always make a mix sound 'tougher.'"

"The new Cohesion system is going to give other manufactures a run for their money. It's absolutely amazing. The CP218 subs yielded sub-notes in the music

tracks that I hadn't heard on any other system that I was on during festival, promo, and one-off runs. It's a beast."



Monitor engineer Andy Ebert has been with The Weeknd on and off since the beginning and is “very happy that [Abel] is now getting the recognition he deserves. I’m mixing on the Avid Profile console, have been since it first came out. The surface’s layout works better for me than other digital consoles, and the plug-in integration is amazing.

“We are using 66 inputs on this tour,” Ebert continues. “I am using 12 IEM mixes, a drum sub and a few direct outs, running a total of 28 outputs. My standard plug-in rack contains: Smack compressor and Phoenix Dark Essence on kick drums, Bomb Factory BF76 and Phoenix Dark Essence on snares, and an SPL Transient Designer on each drum. The Phoenix makes the drums sound more analog. The SPL is the handiest tool to easily tighten up the sound of any drum—it allows you to add attack and sustain, or take it out. It is amazing! On bass I use a Fairchild 660 compressor and Digidesign Reel Tape Saturation. On Abel’s vocal I use a Rane Serato dynamic compressor in addition to the onboard channel compressor. I am using TC Electronic NonLin2 reverb on drums and the onboard ReVibe for vocals, guests and guest instruments.

“On this tour we switched to Shure PSM 1000 IEMs. They sound great, have a great stereo image and the RF is extremely stable. In the past it was not always easy to find frequencies that were free of occasional hisses—even though they appeared to be clean. The Shure makes this almost a non-issue. The PSM 1000 are much cleaner, which makes it faster to find working frequencies every day.



Drummer Ricky Lewis has a mix of Shure and Sennheiser mics, according to drum tech Terry Staley: Beta 91A (the one with an XLR out on the mic) and a Beta 52 on kick drum; SM57 for top and bottom on both snares; and Sennheiser e604 on three rack toms and two floor toms; KSM 32 for overheads; and KSM 137 on hi-hat and ride cymbal.



“Keyboardist and bassist ‘LJ’ Jones has six keyboards split into two line mixers,” says **guitar and keyboard tech Andy Mennen**. “The bass keys are: Korg MS2000, Roland V-Synth GT and a Roland Gaia. I then run a line out of the aux send

to the bass amp. The bass amp is a Fender super Bassman with a 4x10 and a 1x15. This amp choice was based on a few things, the most important of which being that it has two inputs—one for bass guitar and one for bass keys—and a lot of power. When you add in the 1x15 instead of a second 4x10, it handles the low bass key frequencies much better. The other keyboards are Korg Kronos, Roland Fantom G7 and the Roland Jupiter 80.”

Guitar player Patrick Greenaway has two Fender amps, a talkback mic, SM58, and two additional AKG C 414 mics placed lower on the stand. “We started using the Audio-Technica 2500 mic,” says monitor engineer Ebert, “one on the clean amp, one on the distorted amp. The mic has two capsules time-aligned built into one housing. The cable splits into two channels, one dynamic, one condenser. The combination of the two channels sounds great.”



“We have been using the Sennheiser SKM 5200-II handheld mic for a few years now,” monitor engineer Ebert says. “Abel loves the feel of it and how light it is. At the end of 2013 we switched from a Neumann capsule that picked up a lot of surrounding sounds to a Sennheiser MD-5235 capsule. It has a much tighter pattern and it is much more forgiving when Abel cups the capsule.”